

is the fact that they're usually interested in web services, but are still also on tight budgets. It's still a numbers game if you're going to successfully make money in this business, and we've dedicated a whole chapter to how you can market to them. However, in order to make sure you're not selling ice boxes to Eskimos, you need to be a little innovative with your offerings. Even if a business already has a web site, and may even have a customised email solution set up, you can still act as a consultant and help them market their business online on social networks, appropriate forums and discussion boards and also help integrate their services by using a CRM or even re-design web sites. The possibilities are limitless, or to put it more appropriately, limited only by your skills and imagination.

A good thumb rule to follow is to consider how you can offer a service that would help a small business increase their profitability. This may or may not be through a web site, and the benefits may range from informing more people about the business to just easing the delivery of goods, or enabling web-based orders or appointments for services.

2.2 Starting local

As we've mentioned before, although you can target small business from absolutely anywhere, it perhaps makes sense to start locally. It's a trust thing. If you live close to the businesses you approach, they're more likely to hear you out. For example, approaching your local supermarket, or the dentists in your area might help you get started earning that reputation you so sorely need. Of course when we say local, we don't specifically mean starting with just the businesses within a radius of 200 m of your home, but also leveraging your existing contacts. These could be your father's friends who may not even live in the same city, but would definitely hear you out when you're making your pitch, or your family doctor, or business contacts, etc.

Another good place to get some contacts are your city's yellow pages. It makes sense to do this after you've met a few clients, understood their needs, and if possible, after you've actually provided a few businesses with some solutions. When approaching companies you don't know, it's always good to have some sort of portfolio built up. But more on that in our chapter on how to market yourself... for now, let's take an example.

Let's say you meet with your dentist, or your father's friend happens to be a dentist who has a successful practice, but doesn't have a web site or use web services in anyway. Because it's someone you know, you approach this dentist and convince him or her to let you set up a site, an email solution, and say, a Facebook fan page. A simplistic example actually, and probably easy to accomplish, but valuable, because you now have something to show the whole list of dentists in your yellow pages copy that you want to approach.